Ramaswamy Naidu and police station officer S. Gurunathaiyar against assisting the Swadeshi company. Unable to put up with the pressure, both policemen sought to take leave of absence. Gurunathaiyar was even transferred to Kulasekarapatnam.[52] (As we shall see, Gurunathaiyar left the police force and joined SSNCo as cargo superintendent. He acted as VOC's private secretary and confidante.)

The correspondent of *Swadesamitran* wondered if it was right for the British, who prided themselves on their fairness, to indulge in such underhand methods; ironically, he expected the government to intervene and ensure a level playing field.[53]

> … the local officials [said VOC], except the then Sub-Magistrate [G.T.H. Bracken], openly took sides with the B.I.S.N. Co. and troubled us much. There were several prosecutions against several servants and agents of the Swadeshi Company and all of them were thrown out.[54]

With the Swadeshi company gathering steam and putting up a tough fight, tempers ran high and often spilled into the streets. As the rival companies had offices across the street from the railway station, where heavy canvassing by the touts and volunteers was the norm, trouble was always around the corner. Police presence was ordered. But one day, when the police were not present, fisticuffs ensued. Murugaiah, an employee of the Swadeshi firm and the railway ticket collector had an altercation. The police, as could be expected, interceded on the side of the railway employee, arrested Murugaiah and produced him before the sub-magistrate without even giving him time to inform his employer or hire a pleader. He was sentenced to a week's rigorous imprisonment and a fine of Rs 10. The Swadeshi firm could only move for bail, but the incident was the talk of the town.[55] Incidents such as these reinforced public perception about the partisan attitude of European officials and fuelled the patriotic spirit. *The Hindu*, which reported this case in some detail, and made note of two similar cases, pointed out that the lower-level judiciary was biased.[56]

BI hired hoodlums to intimidate traders and passengers. Volunteers and touts vied with each other to win custom. An innovative method adopted by